

Folk Forum

Fall/Winter 2026

Hello friends,

Lately, I've been thinking about Oak Center. Not the general store and not the music, but the "unincorporated community" itself. Between Lake City and Zumbro Falls, at the junction of Wabasha county roads 31, 75, 82, U.S. 63, to county roads 3, 16, 33, that's what's considered Oak Center today. The Black family cemetery, a construction company, a pet-food ingredient processor, our neighbors, and us. Oak Center was named for a grove of oak trees that once stood in its place, one little stitch in a larger patchwork of scattered oaks sprawled over an understory of prairie grasses. This unique ecological community, defined as an oak savannah, requires regular fire in order to not become a woodland. For thousands of years, indigenous people carefully maintained the landscape for hunting. European settlers saw the sparsely wooded grassland and proclaimed that God had gifted them the perfect farmland. The Dakota were systematically squeezed out and onto reservations. Fire was replaced with the plow and the oak trees with agricultural fields. Memories of the oak savannah faded into obscurity in a matter of generations.

Sometimes visitors of the store will say something about how the building feels out of place, in the middle of nowhere like this. Like trying to remember the oak savannah, it's difficult to envision Oak Center as the self-reliant rural farming community it once was. What remains of this bygone era are the stories; we have been lucky to talk to old-timers who attended the nearby schoolhouse as children, or bought hot dogs from the Siewerts, whose parents met at a square dance at the hall here or at the Silver Moon Log Cabin across the street, which was built when the dances were so popular that our music hall upstairs was deemed too small. We've heard about

the playground and a baseball diamond down the road, a place for the kids to hang around after a day of walking the beans or making hay. We've come across newspaper articles documenting when the community would make the trek to a frozen Lake Pepin to harvest ice blocks, and all-day picnics the creamery would put on to benefit the community, offering bottomless lemonade and buttermilk.

It used to be that you couldn't throw a rock without hitting a community like Oak Center. A drive on the backroads will take you by small green road signs indicating you are driving through one, when it seems to be nothing but a rundown storefront, a couple of machine sheds, and a conglomeration of houses surrounded by acres of corn and soy. The desertedness serves as a reminder of a blink in time, what rose out of the ashes of the Great Depression only to be lost again, to the bankruptcies, foreclosures, forced evictions, and the ensuing slew of suicides, divorce, alcoholism, and whole families and communities split asunder in the late 70s and early 80s - a great upheaval of the life they knew and loved. I think of an interview of a struggling young farmer of Glencoe, Minnesota in the 1985 documentary *God's Country*: "I don't know if you can realize what it feels like to live on a farm and to love the land. It's like loving your kids or your wife, you know, to love the land. It's a different feeling inside of you. Maybe you don't know what I'm talking about, but it's just a feeling, it just grabs you right inside, right in the middle of you."

It seems at times like we all suffer from mass amnesia about what these rural places have been and what they have meant to people. But these ghost towns and country roads are full of clues to the past if

you know where to look. There are enduring oak trees lining the highways, suffocating under thickets of dense brush and woods. There are sacred monuments and resting places hidden in the bluffs and developments, and ancient squash seeds buried in the coulees. There are abandoned farmhouses, and boxelder trees growing through tractor implements. Barns that once held rousing parties fell over years ago. Limestone churches turning into limestone dust. In its relatively short life Oak Center has known nothing but constant change and collective forgetting, and yet here we are, clinging to this old building that can't seem to die. People visit us from all over and all walks of life, spontaneously pulling over to peep in the window or come outside, find someone to talk to, ask questions, to tell their story to. This place has the power to draw people in, to grab them right inside; I think we are all missing the deeply communal spirit - the connection to each other, to traditions, and to the land - that used to reside here. We hope in some small way we can keep it alive.

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Today, we are inspired by the rural people of Pine Island, Hermantown, Harmony, and Farmington, organizing against the richest and scariest corporations of modern day, to stop further destruction of this land and our lives through the construction of Data Centers and AI - brave folks leading the fight in a battle that involves all of us and our futures. It is hard to look down the barrel of this gun and think that we stand a chance, when we have seen workers lose in the name of technological progress for centuries now. We at the OCGS won't feign interest in hearing what we can gain from AI - we are much more concerned by what we are losing, and what is already lost, as we continue to wake up every morning to possibly the loneliest time in history. From now on, sharing meals and resources, asking a stranger for directions, writing letters, dancing together, growing food, continuing traditions, leaving your phone at home (or blowing it up), sitting on the porch looking out, and helping out your neighbors are radical acts against the artificial. We can look to rural communities of days gone by (and still kicking) for inspiration. People who made do with what they had, whose social networks and resourcefulness got them through hard times, who

worked with their hands and the dirt, who came from nothing, who were here long before us.

Continuing the work here means a lot to us. We enjoy providing opportunities for people to get together to listen to music and connect. The need for such opportunities is dire! Now that we are more comfortable in this role, we are going to welcome back some of Steven's old ways that got lost in the shuffle. For one, we are ditching the card terminals and going back to a simpler cash-only system at our store. You can still buy tickets online or through mail in check form, or by stopping by the store and dropping off some cash. We hope to bring back an aspect of the donation-based buffet table in the form of some sort of free offering at each show, likely soup. We will have a pay-what-you-can option available at the door for non-sold out shows. This year, we will also be co-hosting three social dances at different community centers with our friends at Oxheart Farm, one in October, one in February, and one in April. This winter, our friend Lauren of Owatonna will be staying with us and you'll probably see her around, so say hello! Whether it's stacking hay or weaving a cattail hat she can basically do anything backwards with her eyes closed and we are lucky to have her around.

Lastly, Folk Forum received a grant from DOPT called [Activate Rural Learning Lab](#). Over the next 2 years, we will receive technical assistance from the DOPT team and share/learn from the 9 other awesome recipients of the grant. We are still in the beginning stages of this, but are super excited. The grant also came with some much need funding that we will mostly be putting towards restoring the building! Yay new roof!

We have a fun line-up for you this season, including first-timers as well as artists with a long-standing history here. There will even be a Christmas play! Will we see you? I hope so!

Much love,
from the Janitorial Staff

Earthly Notes:

Welcome to Earthly Notes! Earthly Notes was a section in Steven's Folk Forum newsletters of yore that helped to spread info about "sister" events in the area. If you are hosting an event, let us know and we can get the word out to our email list, or include it in the next newsletter! Here is what we know about now:

Be a part of the fight against data centers by taking part in the Ride for Responsibility in Cannon Falls, put on by the Farmington-based Coalition for Data Center Responsibility! Bring your bike to 500 Main Street West at 8:00 am on October 3rd. There are several more events spreading data center awareness listed in the event section of stopthepineislanddatacenter.org

The **26th Annual Oak Center Corn Shredding Autumn Harvest Days** will be held the last weekend of September at the Gehrken family farm at 64245 355 Avenue, Lake City, MN! This year featuring Ford tractors! There will be blacksmithing, buttermaking, tractor pulls, live music, and the like. I love to go to get the yearly \$5 collector's button. We may show our tractor in the Parade of Power this year... you gotta be there to know for sure!

Lake Pepin- we all love it! We all want the best for it! On Tuesday, September 22nd, **Lake Pepin Legacy Alliance is hosting a public town hall** featuring "perspectives on sediment, erosion solutions, funding tools, and long-term stewardship" of beautiful Lake Pepin on the Mississippi River. The Anderson Center at Tower View in Red Wing, 5:30-7:30PM.

The Lake City Catholic Workers are raising money to build a beverage building and education space on their farm in 2027. This building will allow them to grow their work in hospitality, beverage fermentation, restoration agriculture, and community. Paul and Sara have welcomed hundreds of unhoused people to live and work in community with them over the last two decades. They have also helped an entire town get addicted to kombucha! Delicious kombucha made onsite using only fair-trade and locally grown ingredients! Once you try the stuff you will be hooked! Consider donating to

these cool people doing great work in our community. You can do so on their website: lakecitycw.com

Donations to our own **Oak Center General Store Preservation Fund** on our website are welcome. We are still in the fixing-up phase here, as materials and labor are very expensive. Currently we are hoping to raise funds for new windows. Every little bit helps!

Interested in volunteering? Email us at oakcentergeneralstoremn@gmail.com. We also accept help thru donation, which can take place on our website, or via a check in the mail.

Music Schedule:

Sleeping Jesus

Friday, October 9, 7:30 pm

This Minneapolis-based force piece outfit, with connections to Nelson, WI, will be making their folk forum debut as our first show of the season! Sleeping Jesus has been playing for 10 years and can take you to many places, from a smoke-filled honky tonk to a rock n' roll basement to rockin' you to sleep like a little baby with a 70s reminiscent folk sound. They've been bringing their newly recorded album "Shotgun" around the Midwest this year. Let's give 'em a big Oak Center welcome this October!

Jason Dea West

Friday, October 16, 7:30 pm

Jason Dea West is a troubadour, songwriter, and poet, taking his honest & poignant songs from coast to coast, from bar to barn. Dea West spent his youth hopping trains and busking around in the likes of many American greats. His unique sound blending folk, blues, vintage country, and outlaw country will have you a-cryin, a-laughin, and a-tappin your foot. We are honored to host Jason and his band for the first time and hoping to see you all there!

**Dean Magraw: Songs of Community Sunday,
October 18, 4:00 pm**

Perhaps you have seen Dean at Oak Center before playing alongside the late and great Peter Ostroushko, or the talented singer Bruce Henry and percussionist Daryl Boudreaux, or kicking it back with my own brother Joe Schwen. If you have, then you know why we can't ever say no to another Dean show. With his brilliant versatility in playing Celtic, soul, jazz, and traditional, and his unique and humorous stage presence, there's a little something here for everyone. Come feel closer to your fellow human at this Sunday afternoon show with Dean's "Songs of Community".

**Community Folk Dance
Saturday, October 24, 6:00 pm
Nelson Community Hall, Nelson WI**

Putting on these dances has been equally as rewarding as the concert series. Having the opportunity to sit down and eat with each other one minute and then swing each other round and round the next. We hope you can attend this very jolly festivity! It's always fun and the music and calling is always cream of the crop. Square dances, contra dances, polka, schottische, and more! No experience necessary! Come one, come all!

**Pop Wagner Trio
Friday, October 30, 7:30 pm**

I've heard there's nothing scarier than Pop Wagner without his cowboy hat. Luckily, I have not yet had to bear such a sight. Joining us on the Eve of Halloween is the one & only Pop! He's bringing along champion fiddler Smack Young Walser and the great Mumblin' Drew. The old-time tunes, cowboy favorites, and rope tricks are sure to make you hoot and holler. I love this band and you will, too! Come see for yourself! Should we make it a costume party? Let's all dress like Pop!! Better get started on your mustaches.

**Steam Machine
Friday, November 6, 7:30 pm**

Steam Machine will be making their debut on the Oak Center stage with some of the hottest bluegrass our great state has to offer. This star-studded band, the incredible Fiddlin' AJ Srubas, strong and steady Rina Rossi on guitar, virtuosic David Robinson on banjo, and the Texas gentleman Beau Sample on bass, will not just blow off your socks, but obliterate them, so it might be better to not wear socks at all! You don't want to miss this rip-roarin' show!

**Switchback
Saturday, November 14, 7:30 pm**

The most iconic Irish Duo of our region has been playing together for years, and graced the Oak Center stage time and time again, even making an appearance on the collectible Oak Center General Store CD (grab a copy next time you are around)! Brian Fitzgerald and Michael McCormack bring energy and spirit everywhere they go. The duo has acquired a long list of recognition and well-deserved accolades over their years of playing. They are versatile and fun. Come on out!!!

**Creekbed Carter Hogan
Sunday, November 22, 4:00 pm**

For the first time and hopefully not the last, we will be hosting Creekbed Carter, as he brings his new album Peasants Revolt around the country! They have shared the stage with the likes of Nick Shoulders, EmmyLou Harris, and Willie Carlsisle. "Hogan's songs have achieved the rare feat of braiding the personal and the political as a means of bringing people together." Let's be brought together!

**A Very Good Christmas Carol
Sunday, December 13, 5:00 pm**

Did you know back in the 20s, our hall used to host a whole lotta dramatic plays? There are numerous theater group signatures in our sound room to prove it! Well, we are bringing it back for a very festive two-actor retelling of Charles Dickens' *A Christmas Carol*. This is not a children's play, although it's also not *not* a children's play, so bring your child, bring your grandma, your girlfriend, your ma, and your pa - and expect a little audience participation. We'll have a Christmas market and activities downstairs, and some festive treats!

Clover and Bee

Friday, December 18, 7:30 pm

“Clover & the Bee” is an off-shoot of esteemed bluegrass band The High 48s featuring our neighbor Oronoco’s Becky Schlegel, as well as Eric Christopher, Anthony Ihrig, and Kevin Rowe. Named after a line in an Emily Dickinson poem titled “To Make a Prairie”, this group of songwriters seeks to create a new sound that's “as free and expansive as the flatlands of the Upper Midwest.”

David Huckfelt

Saturday, January 16, 7:30pm

Let’s give a warm welcome back to poet, lyricist, folk singer, and activist, David Huckfelt! He has shared the stage with many greats, such as Iris Dement, John Trudell, Bon Iver, and Gregory Alan Isakov. This quote from American Songwriter is a good descriptor of what we are in for: “Huckfelt places his voice in conversation with voices that came before, creating something that feels less like a tradition covers album and more like an act of acknowledgement, respect, curiosity, and care.”

Calendar in Brief

October 9 - Sleeping Jesus
 16 - Jason Dea West
 18 - Dean Magraw
 24 - Community Dance
 30 - Pop Wagner Trio

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 14 - Switchback
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January 16 - David Huckfelt

Oak Center General Store
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